> From this it would appear that your intention is to separate yourself from the race of Islam. My respected friend, this is the word of God that has now come to pass. The wise and holy men of this land have during the last four happy months had wonderful dreams and seen visions showing that our Holy Prophet and the Four Friends [the first four Caliphs, or Charyar] have girded up their loins and buckled on their swords in the cause of Islam. The whole of Islam is united with one heart, and we have engaged in a war against the Infidel. The race of unbelievers have been overcome and altogether destroyed. This is not a matter of Man's judgement, but for that of God. You should be keeping your eye steadily fixed on the interests of your religion . . . Judge for yourself whether it is better that you and I should live and be respected among Mussulmans, or that we should pass our lives among Kafirs? If you desire the good of Islam consider my own house and wealth as your own, but if you continue to prefer the company of Kafirs we cannot have relations. Let me hear from you quickly.[42]

The appeal struck all the right chords: Akbar Khan's army quickly swelled as news of his growing prestige as a successful wager of the jihad spread through the mountains. Mirza 'Ata was among his many cheerleaders:

> Sardar Muhammad Akbar Khan the Ghazi set about besieging the English garrison and had criers go around the countryside calling out 'Whoever is a true Muslim must obey the verse of the Qur'an: "Fight in God's way with your wealth and your own selves, that is best for you, if you but knew."' He encouraged everyone to join the struggle against the Christians. As a result of this proclamation, 2,000 enthusiastic young fighters joined his forces. When this young hero was released from detention in Bukhara and came to Kabul, he had no state or wealth. Now his treasury overflowed with plunder taken from the English, and his armouries with their muskets and powder-stores. Thousands of brave warriors followed his victorious stirrups. His plan was to capture English officers alive and to take over their treasury as he had done already in Kabul, so that he could ensure the release of his father Amir Dost Mohammad Khan from captivity in India. For two months he remained outside Jalalabad besieging the garrison and digging trenches and breastworks.[43]

By the end of March, the besiegers had successfully inched forward and brought their siege engines and stockades to within eighty yards of the city walls. No food at all was now entering the city and supplies were growing daily more depleted. All Akbar Khan lacked was good artillery to effect a breach. But in Sale he had a far more spirited opponent than any he had faced in Kabul. Every camp servant within the walls was now armed, and even the syces and camel men had been issued with home-made pikes so that they could help man the walls, especially when the garrison made sorties. If the defenders were short of ammunition they would hold up a life-size dummy with a cocked hat above the parapet to attract fire, then in the evening, when the besiegers had retired to their camp, they would go outside and collect all the spent bullets, which were then run into moulds